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STD::SIMD IS A RANGE

ABSTRACT

P1928 “std::simd — merge data-parallel types from the Parallelism TS 2” promised a paper on making simd a range. This paper explores the addition of iterators to basic_simd and basic_simd_mask.

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1

CHANGELOG

1.1

CHANGES FROM REVISION 0

Previous revision: P3480R0

- Simplify to a single iterator class template.
- Remove incorrect `operator-` overload.
- Discuss design choice of using a sentinel type for `end()`.

1.2

CHANGES FROM REVISION 1

Previous revision: P3480R1

- Add SG9 poll results.
- Use `default_sentinel_t` instead of a new sentinel type.
- Use an almost-mutable iterator type as directed by SG9 for non-const `begin()`.
- Fix `for_each` example to use `ranges` version.

1.3

CHANGES FROM REVISION 2

Previous revision: P3480R2

- Ask about tuple interface for `simd`.
- Clarify where `[simd.iterator]` should go.
- Provide proper wording.
- Fix `<=>` comparison with `default_sentinel_t`.
- Bump feature test macro?

1.4

CHANGES FROM REVISION 3

Previous revision: P3480R3

- Adjust names after introduction of the `simd` subnamespace.

1.5

CHANGES FROM REVISION 4

Previous revision: P3480R4

- Change `iterator_category` to `input_iterator_tag` and add `iterator_concept` as `random_access_iterator_tag`.
- Change `int` to `simd-size-type` in constructor.
- Swap `constexpr` and `friend`.
- Drop `operator<=>` with `default_sentinel_t`.
- Drop `#if LEWG_WANTS_CONVERSION`, keeping the converting constructor.
- Drop precondition on `offset_` for `operator*`.

2

STRAW POLLS

2.1

SG9 AT WROCŁAW 2024

Poll: We want `std::basic_simd` to be a range.

SF	F	N	A	SA
6	2	0	0	0

Poll: We want `std::basic_simd` to be a common range.

SF	F	N	A	SA
0	0	3	4	1

Poll: We want `std::basic_simd::operator[]` and `std::basic_simd::begin/end` in C++26 without mutation support, knowing that we might not be able to do it later due to ABI issues (e.g. `decltype(auto) f(std::simd<float> x) { return x[0]; }` could change return type).

SF	F	N	A	SA
6	2	0	0	0

Poll: We want `std::basic_simd::iterator` and `std::basic_simd::const_iterator` to be different types to make the transition to mutable iteration easier. This also means adding a non-const `begin()` overload that returns a different type than the const `begin()` overload but currently has the same semantics.

SF	F	N	A	SA
2	3	3	0	0

Poll: Use `std::default_sentinel_t` instead of `simd-iterator-sentinel`.

→ unanimous consent

Poll: Forward P3480R1 with the changes above to LEWG for inclusion in C++26.

SF	F	N	A	SA
7	1	0	0	0

2.2

LEWG TELECON 2025-04-08

ACTION: Apply the fix: apply what's in `#if LEWG_WANTS_CONVERSION`

Poll: Modify “P3480R4: `std::simd` is a range” with the above action items and forward to LWG for C++29 (with a recommendation to make this a DR for 26)

SF	F	N	A	SA
10	8	0	0	0

Poll: Modify “P3480R4: `std::simd` is a range” with the above action items and forward to LWG with a recommendation to apply for C++26 (if possible).

SF	F	N	A	SA
12	5	2	0	0

3

INTRODUCTION, OR WHY SIMD WASN'T A RANGE IN THE TS

The Parallelism TS 2 was based on C++17. Ranges were added in C++20. Before ranges, an iterator category was tied to whether `operator*` of iterators returned an lvalue reference. Since `basic_simd` and `basic_simd_mask` objects are not composed of sub-objects (in other words, a `simd<int>` contains no `int` objects), `operator[]` returns prvalues (or a proxy reference in the TS for the non-const case). An iterator needs to do the same and thus never could be in any other iterator category than `Cpp17InputIterator`. In reality, the iterator category always was “random access” (never contiguous; because while `basic_simd` is a contiguous range in memory it isn't one in the object model of C++). In order to not cement that mismatch, it was never proposed to make `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` a range for the TS.

Now that the iterator concepts don't require an lvalue reference anymore we can easily make `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` a read-only range. Iterator dereference would return a prvalue (a copy of the value stored in the `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` object). In addition, the abstraction of a sentinel instead of an iterator pointing beyond the last value of the `basic_simd` seems like a useful tool for `basic_simd`.

4

MOTIVATION

After the technical reasons for *not* adding iterators to `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` are resolved, we still need to consider why `basic_simd` should be a range in the first place.

5

INTEGRATION WITH THE STANDARD LIBRARY

We can improve integration of `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` with the rest of the standard library. By making `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` a range many of the existing facilities in the standard library become easily accessible. All of these facilities do work as intended — in other words: presenting `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` as a range matches on the semantic level, not only syntactically.

5.1

READ-ONLY SUBSCRIPT SHOULD IMPLY READ-ONLY ITERATION

With the latest WD we can write

```
std::datapar::simd<int> v = ...;
for (int i = 0; i < v.size(); ++i) {
    do_something(v[i]);
}
```

Why then, can we not also write

```
for (auto x : v) {
    do_something(x);
}
```

and

```
std::ranges::for_each(v.begin(), v.end(), [](auto x) {
    do_something(x);
});
```

and

```
v | std::views::filter([](auto x) { return x > 0; }) | std::ranges::to<std::vector>();
```

C++ users have learned that whenever a for loop with subscript does what they need to do, then a ranged for loop, standard algorithm, or range adaptor are valid alternatives. This expectation should not get an exception with `basic_simd` and `basic_simd_mask`.

5.2

PRESENT A RANGE OF SIMD AS A RANGE OF SIMD'S VALUE-TYPE

In some applications it is more efficient (and simpler) to work with `basic_simd` objects internally, instead of constantly doing loads and stores. Thus a fairly simple container that comes up in applications could be `std::vector<std::datapar::simd<float>>`. On I/O such an application typically cannot communicate in `basic_simd` objects anymore. Instead it needs to present a range of floats.

Read-only iterators on `basic_simd` do not help with the input side. But for output we can easily turn the `vector<simd<float>>` into a range of `float`:

```
std::vector<std::datapar::simd<float>> data;
auto range_of_float = data | std::views::join;
```

6

DOWNSIDES OF MAKING `SIMD` A RANGE

Really, I can't think of any downsides of making `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` a range. In principle one could argue that `basic_simd/basic_simd_mask` is not a container [P0851R0]. Consequently, it shouldn't have a container interface and thus no iterators. But then we should probably remove the subscript operator as well.

7

DESIGN CHOICE: SENTINEL

The `basic_simd` iterator type must have a reference/pointer to the `basic_simd` object it is iterating together with an offset, where into the `basic_simd` it is pointing. Because of these two members (and their type), the iterator already knows the complete bounds of the range it is pointing into. Consequently, a single `basic_simd` iterator can always determine whether it points at the beginning or end of the range, it doesn't need to compare against another offset. A sentinel type allows asking that question via `operator==`. Thus, instead of comparing two runtime offset members on `operator==`, a compare against a sentinel is implemented as a compare against a compile-time constant. This makes it easier for the compiler to optimize and reduces the size of the `end()` sentinel to a single byte (empty type).

8

OPEN QUESTION: ADD TUPLE INTERFACE

`std::array` implements the tuple interface. Should `std::simd` also implement `tuple_size`, `tuple_element`, and `get`?

9

WORDING

9.1

FEATURE TEST MACRO

In [version.syn] bump the `__cpp_lib_simd` version.

9.2

ADD `[SIMD.ITERATOR]`

Add a new subclause before §29.10.6 [`simd.class`]:

[`simd`]

(9.2.1) 29.10.6 Class *simd-iterator*

[simd.iterator]

```

namespace std::datapar {
    template <class V>
    class simd-iterator {          // exposition only
        V* data_ = nullptr;        // exposition only
        simd-size-type offset_ = 0; // exposition only

    public:
        using value_type = typename V::value_type;
        using iterator_category = std::input_iterator_tag;
        using iterator_concept = std::random_access_iterator_tag;
        using difference_type = simd-size-type;

        constexpr simd-iterator() = default;
        constexpr simd-iterator(V& d, simd-size-type off);

        constexpr simd-iterator(const simd-iterator&) = default;
        constexpr simd-iterator& operator=(const simd-iterator&) = default;

        constexpr simd-iterator(const simd-iterator<remove_const_t<V>>&) requires is_const_v<V>;

        constexpr value_type operator*() const;

        constexpr simd-iterator& operator++();
        constexpr simd-iterator operator++(int);
        constexpr simd-iterator& operator--();
        constexpr simd-iterator operator--(int);

        constexpr simd-iterator& operator+=(difference_type n);
        constexpr simd-iterator& operator-=(difference_type n);

        constexpr value_type operator[](difference_type n) const;

        friend constexpr bool operator==(const simd-iterator a, const simd-iterator b) = default;
        friend constexpr bool operator==(const simd-iterator a, default_sentinel_t);
        friend constexpr auto operator<=>(const simd-iterator a, const simd-iterator b);

        friend constexpr simd-iterator operator+(const simd-iterator& i, difference_type n);
        friend constexpr simd-iterator operator+(difference_type n, const simd-iterator& i);
        friend constexpr simd-iterator operator-(const simd-iterator& i, difference_type n);

        friend constexpr difference_type operator-(const simd-iterator a, const simd-iterator b);
        friend constexpr difference_type operator-(const simd-iterator i, default_sentinel_t);
        friend constexpr difference_type operator-(default_sentinel_t, const simd-iterator i);
    };

```



```
    }
```

```
constexpr simd-iterator(V& d, simd-size-type off);
```

1 *Effects:* Initializes *data_* with *d* and *offset_* with *off*.

```
constexpr simd-iterator(const simd-iterator<remove_const_t<V>>& i) requires is_const_v<V>;
```

2 *Effects:* Initializes *data_* with *i.data_* and *offset_* with *i.offset_*.

```
constexpr value_type operator*() const;
```

3 *Preconditions:* *data_* is a valid pointer.

4 *Effects:* Equivalent to: `return (*data_)[offset_];`

```
constexpr simd-iterator& operator++();
```

5 *Effects:* Equivalent to:

```
    ++offset_;
    return *this;
```

```
constexpr simd-iterator operator++(int);
```

6 *Effects:* Equivalent to:

```
    simd-iterator tmp = *this;
    ++offset_;
    return tmp;
```

```
constexpr simd-iterator& operator--();
```

7 *Effects:* Equivalent to:

```
    --offset_;
    return *this;
```

```
constexpr simd-iterator operator--(int);
```

8 *Effects:* Equivalent to:

```
    simd-iterator tmp = *this;
    --offset_;
    return tmp;
```

```
constexpr simd-iterator& operator+=(difference_type n);
```

```

9      Effects: Equivalent to:
        offset_ += n;
        return *this;

constexpr simd-iterator& operator--(difference_type n);

10      Effects: Equivalent to:
        offset_ -= n;
        return *this;

constexpr value_type operator[](difference_type n) const;

11      Effects: Equivalent to: return (*data_)[offset_ + n];

friend constexpr bool operator==(simd-iterator i, default_sentinel_t);

12      Effects: Equivalent to: return i.offset_ == V::size();

friend constexpr auto operator<=>(simd-iterator a, simd-iterator b);

13      Preconditions: a.data_ == b.data_ is true.
14      Effects: Equivalent to: return a.offset_ <= b.offset_;

friend constexpr simd-iterator operator+(const simd-iterator& i, difference_type n);
friend constexpr simd-iterator operator+(difference_type n, const simd-iterator& i);

15      Effects: Equivalent to: return simd-iterator(*i.data_, i.offset_ + x);

friend constexpr simd-iterator operator-(const simd-iterator& i, difference_type n);

16      Effects: Equivalent to: return simd-iterator(*i.data_, i.offset_ - x);

friend constexpr difference_type operator-(simd-iterator a, simd-iterator b);

17      Preconditions: a.data_ == b.data_ is true.
18      Effects: Equivalent to: return a.offset_ - b.offset_;

friend constexpr difference_type operator-(simd-iterator i, default_sentinel_t);

19      Effects: Equivalent to: return i.offset_ - V::size();

friend constexpr difference_type operator-(default_sentinel_t, simd-iterator i);

20      Effects: Equivalent to: return V::size() - i.offset_;

```

9.3

MODIFY [SIMD.OVERVIEW]

[simd.overview]

```
template<class T, class Abi> class basic_simd {
public:
    using value_type = T;
    using mask_type = basic_simd_mask<sizeof(T), Abi>;
    using abi_type = Abi;
    using iterator = simd-iterator<basic_simd>;
    using const_iterator = simd-iterator<const basic_simd>;

    constexpr iterator begin();
    constexpr const_iterator begin() const;
    constexpr const_iterator cbegin() const;
    constexpr default_sentinel_t end() const;
    constexpr default_sentinel_t cend() const;
```

9.4

MODIFY [SIMD.MASK.OVERVIEW]

[simd.mask.overview]

```
template<size_t Bytes, class Abi> class basic_simd_mask {
public:
    using value_type = bool;
    using abi_type = Abi;
    using iterator = simd-iterator<basic_simd_mask>;
    using const_iterator = simd-iterator<const basic_simd_mask>;

    constexpr iterator begin();
    constexpr const_iterator begin() const;
    constexpr const_iterator cbegin() const;
    constexpr default_sentinel_t end() const;
    constexpr default_sentinel_t cend() const;
```

A

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- [P0851R0] Matthias Kretz. *P0851R0: simd<T> is neither a product type nor a container type*. ISO/IEC C++ Standards Committee Paper. 2017. URL: <https://wg21.link/p0851r0>.